MODEL ANSWER KEY
MG5DSCSOC301 — Indian Social Structure and Transformation
Fifth Semester | Maximum Marks: 70

Based on the uploaded question paper. 26900510

Answers to all questions and alternatives are provided. The marking suggestions are indicative; equivalent explanations and relevant examples should receive credit.

Part A — Short Answers

Answer any 10 questions. Each carries 3 marks.

1. Why is common residence not the sole defining feature of a joint family?

A joint family is defined by continuing relationships, rights and obligations among relatives, rather than residence alone.

- Members may share property, financial responsibilities, ritual duties and mutual support.
- Members living separately because of employment or education may continue to function as part of the joint family.
- Conversely, people sharing a house do not necessarily constitute a joint family unless such kinship obligations exist.

Marking: Shared obligations, continuity despite separate residence, and distinction between household and family — 1 mark each.

2. Why are the experiences of marginalised groups central to the subaltern perspective?

The subaltern perspective studies society from the standpoint of groups subordinated by caste, class, gender or other power relations.

- Elite accounts often overlook the experiences of peasants, workers, Dalits, Adivasis and women.
- Their experiences reveal how domination operates in everyday life.
- Their voices also demonstrate agency through resistance, negotiation and collective action.

Example: Studying a peasant struggle through participants' accounts rather than only official records.

3. Examine communalism as a process that turns religious difference into social or political antagonism.

Communalism develops when religious communities are presented as groups with uniform and opposing interests.

- Religious identities become boundaries separating “us” from “them.”
- Political mobilisation, stereotypes and selective accounts of history portray another community as a threat.
- This can produce discrimination, segregation, hostility and violence.

Religious diversity itself does not necessarily produce communalism; antagonism is socially and politically constructed.

4. Explain three institutions in which gender-sensitive practices are important.

1. **Family:** Equal access to education, shared domestic responsibilities and participation in decisions challenge gender discrimination.
2. **Educational institutions:** Inclusive teaching, equal opportunities and effective responses to harassment support gender equality.
3. **Workplaces:** Equal pay, fair recruitment, promotion opportunities and protection against harassment promote dignity and participation.

Marking: 1 mark for each institution with an appropriate explanation.

5. Examine three ways through which coexistence in a diverse society is supported.

1. **Equal citizenship:** Equal rights and protection against discrimination build security and belonging.
2. **Dialogue and cooperation:** Interaction through neighbourhood groups, schools and workplaces reduces prejudice and builds trust.
3. **Respect for cultural diversity:** Recognition of different languages, religions and customs allows people to preserve their identities while participating in shared social life.

6. Explain two ways in which women’s education and employment can alter family relations.

1. **Greater decision-making power:** Education and independent earnings can increase women’s influence over marriage, household expenditure, childbirth and children’s education.
2. **Changes in gender roles:** Employment can encourage the sharing of domestic work and childcare and challenge the assumption that men alone should earn.

However, women may experience a double burden when paid work increases without a corresponding redistribution of household responsibilities.

Marking: Two explained changes — 1½ marks each.

7. How does the structural-functional perspective view institutions as interconnected social relations?

The structural-functional perspective views society as a system of interdependent institutions.

- Institutions such as family, economy, education and religion consist of organised roles, norms and relationships.
- Each contributes to social continuity through functions such as socialisation, production and regulation.
- A change in one institution affects others.

Example: Expansion of education changes employment opportunities, marriage expectations and family relations.

8. Describe three factors influencing changing rural power.

1. **Changes in landownership and agriculture:** Land reforms, commercial farming and new sources of wealth can alter the influence of traditional landlords.
2. **Democratic politics:** Elections, Panchayati Raj and representation of disadvantaged groups create new opportunities for leadership.
3. **Education and non-farm employment:** Migration, salaried work and access to information can reduce dependence on dominant landowning groups.

9. How do factors other than income shape class position?

- **Wealth and property:** Land, housing and inherited assets provide security and advantages beyond current earnings.
- **Occupation and education:** Job security, qualifications, skills and authority affect life chances.
- **Social background and networks:** Caste, gender, family connections and access to influential people shape opportunities and mobility.

Thus, two people with similar incomes may occupy different class positions because their assets, security and opportunities differ.

10. Explain how three types of sources contribute to the Indological study of Indian society.

1. **Religious and philosophical texts:** The Vedas, Upanishads and Dharmashastras reveal ideas about social duties, hierarchy and moral order.

2. **Epics and literary works:** The Ramayana, Mahabharata and other literature provide representations of kinship, gender, kingship and social values.
3. **Inscriptions and historical records:** Inscriptions, genealogies and chronicles offer evidence about land grants, political authority, religious patronage and social groups.

These sources require critical interpretation because prescribed ideals may differ from everyday practices.

11. Describe the central present-day debate about change and equality in the caste system.

The central debate concerns whether modernisation and democratic change are weakening caste or transforming the ways it operates.

- Education, urbanisation, occupational mobility and legal equality have challenged hereditary restrictions.
- Yet discrimination, endogamy, unequal resources and caste-based exclusion continue.
- Therefore, changes in caste practices do not necessarily indicate the achievement of substantive equality.

12. Describe three dimensions of modernisation.

1. **Economic:** Industrialisation, technological development, market expansion and occupational diversification.
2. **Political:** Growth of democratic participation, citizenship, bureaucratic administration and legal-rational authority.
3. **Social and cultural:** Expansion of education, scientific thinking, individual choice and challenges to inherited status.

Modernisation is uneven and does not automatically eliminate inequality.

13. How can migration reshape caste and class relations?

- Migration may weaken local caste controls by providing anonymity, new occupations and interaction across caste boundaries.
- Earnings and remittances can improve class position and reduce dependence on local landlords or employers.
- However, caste networks may continue to organise recruitment, housing and marriage, while insecure employment may reproduce disadvantage.

Migration can therefore create mobility while also carrying existing inequalities into new settings.

Part B — Short Essays

Answer one question from each pair. Each carries 8 marks.

14(a). Explain the meaning and key dimensions of agrarian change in India.

Agrarian change refers to transformations in agriculture and in the social relationships organised around land, labour and agricultural production. It includes changes in ownership, technology, markets, class relations and rural power.

Landownership and tenure: Land reforms sought to abolish intermediaries, regulate tenancy and redistribute surplus land. Their effects varied across regions. Unequal ownership, insecure tenancy and fragmentation remain significant features of agrarian society.

Technology and production: Irrigation, improved seeds, fertilisers and mechanisation increased agricultural productivity in many areas. The Green Revolution particularly benefited regions and cultivators with access to land, water and capital, contributing to uneven development.

Commercialisation: Cultivation increasingly responds to markets through cash crops, purchased inputs, credit and commercial supply chains. This creates opportunities but also exposes cultivators to fluctuating prices, rising costs and indebtedness.

Labour relations: Hereditary service relationships and personal dependence have weakened in many areas. Wage labour, seasonal migration and mechanisation have altered agricultural employment, although caste and gender inequalities persist.

Class and power relations: Changes in land, credit and production have strengthened some prosperous cultivators and rural entrepreneurs. Small farmers and landless workers often face greater insecurity.

Diversification and migration: Rural households increasingly combine farming with construction work, services, small businesses and migration.

Gender and ecology: Women undertake substantial agricultural work but often lack ownership and decision-making power. Water scarcity, soil degradation and climate variability also shape agrarian livelihoods.

Agrarian change is therefore an uneven transformation of rural production, inequality and power.

Suggested marking: Meaning — 1; explained dimensions — 6; conclusion/example — 1.

14(b). Analyse Ghurye's treatment of tribes and integration, including criticisms of his assimilationist approach.

G. S. Ghurye understood many Indian tribal communities through their historical interaction with the wider Hindu social order. He challenged the idea that tribes were entirely isolated societies.

Tribe–caste connections: Ghurye emphasised cultural contact and similarities between tribal populations and surrounding Hindu communities. He described many tribes as "backward Hindus," reflecting his interpretation that they had varying degrees of incorporation into Hindu society.

Opposition to isolation: He opposed policies that would preserve tribal communities in isolation. He favoured their participation in wider economic, educational and political life.

Assimilation: His approach generally supported incorporation into the wider Hindu social order and national society. Education, communication and economic development were important means of overcoming marginalisation.

Criticisms:

- **Cultural diversity:** The category "backward Hindus" can obscure the distinct religions, languages, institutions and identities of tribal communities.
- **Hindu-centred interpretation:** It treats incorporation into Hindu society as the expected direction of change.
- **Power and exploitation:** Cultural incorporation does not necessarily remove dispossession, indebtedness or exploitation.
- **Autonomy and consent:** Assimilation may neglect communities' rights to determine their own futures.
- **Cultural loss:** Incorporation can undermine indigenous knowledge and collective institutions.

Ghurye's contribution lies in highlighting historical connections between tribes and wider society. However, an adequate approach to integration must combine equal opportunities with cultural recognition, land rights and self-determination.

Suggested marking: Ghurye's approach — 4; criticisms — 3; assessment — 1.

15(a). Discuss discrimination, endogamy and unequal resources as contemporary challenges related to caste.

Caste continues to shape opportunities and relationships despite substantial changes in education, employment and public life.

Discrimination: Caste discrimination can occur in schools, workplaces, housing and public spaces. It includes exclusion, humiliation, prejudiced judgments and unequal treatment. Some forms are overt, while others operate through informal practices and networks.

Example: A qualified person may encounter housing exclusion because of their caste identity.

Endogamy: Marriage within one's caste remains a major mechanism of caste continuity. Families may use caste-based networks and matrimonial preferences to regulate partner selection. Opposition to inter-caste marriage can range from emotional pressure to violence.

Endogamy preserves caste boundaries by linking marriage with family status, inheritance and community membership.

Unequal resources: Historical differences in landownership, education, assets and occupational opportunities continue to influence present outcomes. Families with substantial resources can provide better schooling, financial support and access to influential networks. Disadvantaged households may face insecure work and limited opportunities for accumulation.

Interconnection: Discrimination restricts opportunities, resource inequalities reduce bargaining power, and endogamy helps transmit these advantages and disadvantages across generations.

Addressing caste therefore requires both protection against exclusion and measures that expand access to education, resources, dignified employment and freedom of marriage.

Suggested marking: Introduction — 1; three challenges — 6; conclusion — 1.

15(b). Analyse why modern caste politics is not simply the survival of traditional politics.

Modern caste politics involves the transformation of caste identities through elections, democratic institutions, political parties and struggles over resources.

From inherited authority to electoral mobilisation: Traditional caste authority was closely associated with hereditary status and local dominance. Electoral politics requires leaders to mobilise voters and negotiate support.

Political participation of subordinated groups: Dalit, backward-caste and other movements have challenged established hierarchies. Their mobilisation expresses demands for dignity, representation and redistribution.

New caste organisations: Caste associations may organise education, welfare, employment support and political campaigns. These organisations use modern institutional forms and communication technologies.

Coalition-building: Electoral success often requires alliances across castes. Political blocs are constructed through negotiation rather than determined entirely by ritual hierarchy.

State resources and policy: Representation, reservations, welfare and access to public institutions have become major political concerns. Caste thus becomes a basis for claims upon the modern state.

Changing leadership: Education, organisational ability and political connections can create leaders whose influence does not rest solely on traditional rank.

Continuing contradictions: Caste mobilisation can democratise power, but it can also promote exclusion, elite capture and conflict.

Modern caste politics therefore combines inherited identities with new institutions and aspirations. It may reproduce inequality, but it can also provide a means of challenging it.

Suggested marking: Central argument — 1; analysis — 6; balanced conclusion — 1.

16(a). Examine changing inter-caste relations in work, politics and everyday interaction.

Inter-caste relations have changed through education, migration, democratic participation, economic development and anti-caste struggles. These changes vary across regions and social settings.

Work: Hereditary links between caste and occupation have weakened in many sectors. People from different castes work together in offices, factories, educational institutions and service industries. However, caste networks still influence recruitment and advancement, while stigmatised work remains disproportionately associated with particular communities.

Politics: Electoral democracy has expanded participation and enabled historically disadvantaged groups to challenge dominant castes. Political parties build inter-caste alliances and negotiate competing demands. At the same time, caste competition can generate polarisation and conflict.

Everyday interaction: Shared schools, transport, markets and workplaces have increased contact across caste boundaries. Restrictions on commensality and physical interaction have weakened in many settings.

Continuing boundaries: Greater interaction does not always produce intimate social acceptance. Marriage remains strongly regulated by caste, and exclusion can persist in housing, neighbourhood relations and access to common resources.

Uneven change: Urban anonymity and occupational diversity may weaken some controls, while local dependence and unequal landownership can sustain them elsewhere. Caste discrimination also exists in cities.

Inter-caste relations thus show expanding cooperation alongside continuing hierarchy and contested boundaries.

Suggested marking: Introduction — 1; work, politics and everyday interaction — 6; synthesis — 1.

16(b). Discuss the meaning and major dimensions of women's empowerment.

Women's empowerment is the process through which women gain resources, agency and the ability to make meaningful decisions about their lives. It also involves transforming institutions that sustain gender inequality.

Educational empowerment: Access to education, skills and digital literacy improves knowledge, confidence and opportunities.

Economic empowerment: Access to decent employment, fair earnings, property, credit and control over income strengthens independence and bargaining power.

Political empowerment: Voting, representation, leadership and participation in public decisions enable women to influence policies and institutions.

Social empowerment: Freedom from restrictive norms, violence and discrimination supports mobility, dignity and participation in community life.

Legal empowerment: Awareness of rights and effective access to justice help women challenge unequal treatment and secure entitlements.

Health and bodily autonomy: Access to healthcare and the ability to make informed decisions about marriage, sexuality and reproduction are essential.

Psychological empowerment: Self-confidence and recognition of one's capacity to act help women express preferences and challenge domination.

Example: A self-help group may offer savings and credit while also enabling collective action and leadership.

Empowerment requires actual control and choice. Employment or formal representation alone may have limited effects if others continue to control women's decisions.

Suggested marking: Meaning — 2; explained dimensions — 5; example/conclusion — 1.

17(a). Explain the structure and key characteristics of the Indian village community.

The Indian village community is a rural settlement whose members are connected through residence, livelihoods, kinship, institutions and everyday interaction. Villages differ considerably across regions.

Agrarian foundation: Agriculture and related activities have historically shaped village livelihoods, social relations and seasonal routines.

Caste differentiation: Many villages contain several caste groups, sometimes living in distinct neighbourhoods. Caste has influenced status, occupation and access to resources.

Class inequality: Differences between landowners, tenants, small cultivators and landless workers create unequal economic positions.

Family and kinship: Families, lineages and marriage networks organise inheritance, support and social obligations.

Local power: Landownership, caste position, wealth and political connections influence leadership. Panchayats provide formal institutions of local governance.

Religious and cultural life: Festivals, religious institutions and local traditions can generate shared participation, although participation may also reflect exclusion and hierarchy.

Cooperation and conflict: Villagers may cooperate in cultivation, ceremonies and local development while also competing over land, wages, water and political authority.

External connections: Villages are linked to towns, markets, migration networks, government agencies and digital communication.

The village should therefore be understood as a changing and internally differentiated community, rather than a uniformly harmonious or self-sufficient unit.

Suggested marking: Meaning — 1; structure and characteristics — 6; critical observation — 1.

17(b). Analyse how endogamy reproduces caste as a closed social group across generations.

Endogamy means marriage within a defined social group. Caste endogamy restricts marriage to members of the same caste or recognised subgroup, thereby maintaining caste boundaries.

Control of membership: Restricting marriage limits the formation of family relationships across castes. Children are generally assigned a caste identity through descent, allowing membership to continue across generations.

Transmission of resources: Marriage within caste helps circulate property, wealth and social connections within established networks.

Preservation of hierarchy: Families may treat marriage as a means of maintaining caste status, preventing unions that challenge inherited distinctions.

Socialisation: Children learn caste preferences through family expectations, marriage practices, community networks and everyday discussion.

Regulation of sexuality: Control over women's partner choices and sexuality plays a particularly important role in maintaining caste boundaries.

Sanctions: Inter-caste couples may face emotional pressure, exclusion, withdrawal of support or violence. Such sanctions discourage boundary-crossing.

Modern reproduction: Matrimonial websites, professional networks and educated families may continue caste-based partner selection, showing that modernisation does not automatically end endogamy.

Endogamy consequently connects marriage, descent, property and social control. It is a central mechanism through which caste persists despite changes in occupation and public interaction.

Suggested marking: Definition — 1; mechanisms — 6; conclusion — 1.

18(a). Describe the meaning of caste and explain its major characteristics.

Caste is a system of hereditary social stratification in which groups are differentiated by birth, marriage rules, status and historically associated occupations. In everyday life, caste generally refers to **jati**; the fourfold **varna** scheme is a broader classificatory model.

Major characteristics:

1. **Birth-based membership:** Individuals ordinarily acquire caste membership through birth.
2. **Segmental division:** Society is divided into groups with their own identities, customs and social networks.
3. **Hierarchy:** Castes are placed in unequal status relationships, although rankings can vary and be contested.
4. **Endogamy:** Marriage is generally expected to occur within the caste or subgroup.
5. **Occupational association:** Particular occupations have historically been associated with particular castes.
6. **Restrictions on interaction:** Rules concerning food, commensality, marriage and social contact have regulated relationships.
7. **Purity and pollution:** These ideas have historically justified status differences and practices of exclusion.
8. **Unequal privileges and disabilities:** Access to land, education, religious spaces and authority has been unequally distributed.

These characteristics have changed substantially. Caste continues through a combination of marriage patterns, social networks, inequalities and political identities rather than through an entirely unchanged traditional order.

Suggested marking: Meaning and jati–varna distinction — 2; characteristics — 5; contemporary qualification — 1.

18(b). Describe the risks of digitalisation, including misinformation, surveillance, privacy and the reproduction of inequality.

Digitalisation involves the growing use of digital technologies in communication, work, education, governance and everyday life. Alongside its benefits, it produces significant social risks.

Misinformation: False or misleading content can circulate rapidly through social media and messaging platforms. It can damage reputations, intensify prejudice and encourage poorly informed decisions. Disinformation refers more specifically to deliberately deceptive content.

Surveillance: Governments, companies and other actors can monitor activities through location records, online behaviour, cameras and databases. Excessive monitoring can restrict autonomy and discourage participation or dissent.

Privacy risks: Large-scale collection and sharing of personal data can expose individuals to profiling, identity theft, fraud and unwanted disclosure. Consent may be weakened when users cannot understand or meaningfully refuse data practices.

Digital inequality: Differences in internet access, devices, affordability and skills affect participation in education, employment and public services. Gender, class, caste, disability, age and location can shape these differences.

Reproduction of discrimination: Algorithms trained on unequal or biased data can reproduce disadvantage in recruitment, lending and other decisions.

Exclusion from services: Digital-only systems can disadvantage people who lack connectivity, documentation, language support or technical assistance.

Example: An online application process may expand convenience while excluding applicants without reliable internet or digital literacy.

Addressing these risks requires accessible systems, digital literacy, privacy safeguards, accountable institutions and meaningful alternatives for people facing digital exclusion.

Suggested marking: Meaning — 1; four specified risks — 6; example/conclusion — 1.